

TJ Collamore

Mrs. Everett

World II Honors

28 October 2022

The French Revolution Betrayed the Ideals of Liberty and Equality

During the Age of Reason, a movement called the Enlightenment stressed the power of individuals to solve societal problems. An early philosophe named John Locke believed that all people were born free and equal, and had the natural rights of life, liberty, and property. He emphasized that the purpose of government was to protect these rights and if it failed to do so, then its citizens could overthrow it. Inspired by these ideals, their own economic hardships, and the success of the American Revolution, the citizens of France courageously started their own revolution in 1789. Although Thomas Paine, an American philosopher, defended the French Revolution's challenging of monarchies and dictatorships on the grounds of a lasting principle of peace, the reality was that the ideals that they strove for were not achieved. Unfortunately, their initial success degenerated into infighting, progressively radical behavior, and a lack of progress. Extreme violence during the Great Fear and excessive political executions during the Reign of Terror prevented the ideal of liberty, coupled with negligible progress on women's rights, all betrayed the ideals of liberty and equality for the people of France.

The Great Fear betrayed the pursuit of liberty and equality. When King Louis XVI sent out his army of Swiss guards around Versailles, rumors spread that Louis was going to use military force to expel the National Assembly and massacre citizens. In response, on July 14th of 1789, the people stormed a prison called the Bastille to steal gunpowder. In the process of doing so, the irate attackers killed many of the guards, and shockingly marched the streets with severed

heads on pikes. This unnecessary and gruesome lawlessness stained their previously noble efforts. This scene was a precursor to extended violence, and not the lasting liberty that the authors of the Declaration of the Rights of Man had in mind. If this had truly led to liberty and equality, then one could argue that it was worth it. However, it did not; instead, the villages panicked, fearing that the nobles were hiring outlaws to terrorize the peasants. The ensuing wave of senseless panic ravaged the French countryside. The peasants broke into nobles' homes with pitchforks and farm tools and resorted to theft, destruction, and arson; this was betraying the natural rights of liberty as people's lives and properties were ruined. This Great Fear was also driven by the frighteningly unaffordable price of food. When survival is at risk, that is, when there is a real risk of death from starvation, then lofty goals of liberty and equality become a distant secondary concern. The people of France advanced lawlessness so that they could stay alive, thus betraying the ideals of liberty and equality during the French Revolution.

The societal failure of the Great Fear allowed for the emergence of a dictator to take the people even further from the ideals of the Declaration of the Rights of Man, and into the Reign of Terror. One might argue that the king's signing of the Declaration of the Rights of Man supported the advancement of liberty and equality; however, it did not. Instead, a radical named Maximilien Robespierre emerged as a ruthless leader and created an era of terror, war, and misery. Robespierre, the leader of the Committee of Public Safety and the Jacobins, established a system he described as terror as a virtue. Any person who opposed his way of thinking would be quickly executed by the guillotine. This directly opposed freedom, liberty, and religion, as it forced people to withhold their beliefs in silence, which utterly fails the ideas of Enlightenment. While this was happening, France became dechristianized, and then Robespierre even established his own new religion, the Cult of the Supreme Being. Finally, before achieving liberty and

equality, there must be criminal justice rights; that is, a right to a fair trial and equality before the law. The Reign of Terror betrayed the ideals of liberty and equality for most citizens of the French Revolution.

Unfortunately, the women of the French Revolution were even further victimized, as the ideals of liberty and equality were even less realistic. For example, prestigious professions such as doctors and lawyers were male-dominated. Also, when the Legislative Assembly made a new legislature called the National Convention, they only granted adult male citizens the right to vote and to hold office. Moreover, only men had a right to an education. A famous Enlightenment thinker named Mary Wollstonecraft limited her focus to women's right to an education. She crafted her argument carefully so as to avoid the same fate as the writer Olympe de Gouges, who tried to publish the Declaration of the Rights of Women; her ideas were rejected, she was declared an enemy of the Revolution, and executed.

The French Revolution betrayed the ideals of liberty and equality, as evidenced by the Great Fear, the Reign of Terror, and the lack of advancement of women's rights. The panicked, rebellious, and hungry citizens laid waste to their countryside during the Great Fear. In the subsequent Reign of Terror, citizens were denied criminal rights, freedom of religion, and freedom of speech. Women couldn't be educated, vote, hold office, or work in prestigious professions; they were reduced to marching at Versailles, killing guards while fighting for bread to feed their families. As the British politician Edmund Burke said, "they have found their punishment and their success. Laws overturned; tribunals subverted;... the people impoverished; a church pillaged" (Littell 228). The intent of the French Revolution was just, and the ideals were sound, but the execution of a revolution cannot be haphazard, but rather organized, calculated, and having integrity.